

THE PURPOSE OF THE CHURCH

TEXT: Luke 19:45-48 (NKJV) *“Then He went into the temple and began to drive out those who bought and sold in it,⁴⁶ saying to them, **“It is written, ‘My house is a house of prayer,’ but you have made it a ‘den of thieves.’**”⁴⁷ And He was teaching daily in the temple. But the chief priests, the scribes, and the leaders of the people sought to destroy Him,⁴⁸ and were unable to do anything; for all the people were very attentive to hear Him.”*

In this passage of Scripture we are introduced to a personality trait of Jesus which is rarely seen in Scripture. As He enters the synagogue Jesus is confronted with a group of people who are making their living selling wares of worship. The Scripture makes us aware that Jesus was a regular at the Synagogue. Luke 4:14-16 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus returned in the power of the Spirit to Galilee, and news of Him went out through all the surrounding region.¹⁵ And He taught in their synagogues, being glorified by all. ¹⁶ So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and stood up to read.”* Jesus had a habit of church attendance and if we desire to be like Him we should develop a similar habit.

The point here is that Jesus has no doubt been to this same synagogue on many occasions and witnessed the abuse of worshippers, but this time is different. We are allowed to peer just momentarily into the side of the personality of Jesus which allows Him to become

angry enough to drive the money changers from the place of worship. (If we do not accept mercy, we will eventually get judgment)

When He drives the money changers from the place of worship He makes a statement which we seldom hear but would do well to study if we hope to be the kind of church Jesus would be impressed with. At CT we are not seeking the accolades of men but the approval of the heavenly Father.

I want us to look at the statements of Jesus in this passage of Scripture and make an attempt to discover how it might look in this modern time.

The word translated “**Prayer**” here comes from the Greek word “**Proseuche**” (pros-yoo-khay’) and means “*A place set apart or suited for the offering of prayer and worship.*” If a synagogue was not accessible and the Jews prayed and worshipped in the countryside the chosen place for prayer and worship would always be selected near a creek or stream because they would wash themselves prior to prayer and worship. This act was an act of purifying themselves to come into the presence of Jehovah.

The word translated “**Thieves**” here comes from the Greek word “**Lestes**” (lace-tace’) and means “*A place which has been plundered or taken advantage of.*”

Jesus is saying the church will either be a “**Den of thieves**” or a “**House of prayer.**” I want us to take a look at what a “**Den of thieves**” or a “**House of prayer**” might look like in 2007...

Keep in mind, the church you attend will be what we make it!

If we make it...

A den of thieves it will be angry, abrasive, full of antinomy, and will hold people at arms length!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be ample, articulate, ambulatory, abnormal, and an antidepressant for its community! It will be ready to take care of a need for anyone, at any place and at anytime!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be bitter, backslidden, bizarre, brutal, blind, bemoaning all of its troubles! It will betray its beliefs, bar certain kinds of people; it will bend and then break! It will have money like a bank and will balk when it comes to outreach!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be balanced, benevolent, and will batter the kingdom of darkness, booby trapping the devil and have a baptistery that actually gets used for something besides storage! It will believe the Word of God, be baptized in the Holy Ghost, blossom like a rose, and have a clear view of Beulah land!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be cold, calloused, careless, contrary, comfortable, contented, confined, comatose, and cater to a carnal crowd! It will be ceremonial; full of calamity and will

cannibalizes the saints! It will continue the process of collapsing and will eventually cease!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be called, capable, calculated, cognizant, committed, compassionate, consecrated, cooperative, competent, consistent, conquering, creative, colossal, charismatic, will capitalize on the mistakes the devil makes! It will have conviction in its singing preaching and praying, and no matter how much mud gets slung in its direction it will never cease!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be dead, dry, deceived, depressed, defiled, divided, distracted, decrepit, deformed, declining, demoralized, dirty and in a constant state of denial! It will have a depth deficiency, derelict in its duties and depending on detours to distract its followers! Worst of all, it will aid and abet those who choose to dodge the draft in the army of God!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be determined, developed, devoted and distinctive! It will be diverse and will dawn a different dialect! It will disturb those who are at ease in Zion, drive demons delirious, doom the devil, and will one day dock safely at home!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be empty, egotistical, eccentric, encumbered, expose, extreme, exclusive and endorse an intoxicated lifestyle! It will be full of excess, elude revival and embark on a path of death! It will be ruled by the traditions of the elders, embarrassed to be named among the invisible

Church and attempt to build its own little empire here!
Worst of all, it will impose an embargo on sending
people into the Ministry!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be embattled,
eager, elect, earnest, established, evangelistic,
enlightened, energized, efficient, elevated,
embellished, effectual, empowered, endowed,
expectant, exuberant, ecstatic and possess a
tremendous ability to demonstrate its elasticity! It will
embalm spiritually dead bodies with a solution that
brings them back to life allowing the embers of the
Holy Spirit to start a fire that the fire department from
hell can't put out! It will be the epicenter of the glory
of God in the earth, stand on the edge of eternity and
take sinful humankind with one hand and a forgiving
God with the other hand and bring the two together! It
will be heaven on earth and will be ejected from this
sphere to go sweeping through the pearly gates!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be fashionable,
frivolous, fretful, frustrated, far gone, far fetched,
fussy, full of factions, filled with fatalism, and filled
with failure!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be fair, factual,
faithful, free, fundamental, family oriented, fervent,
full-fledged, fanatical, futuristic, farsighted, far-flung,
full of fellowship, full of faith, and fully furnished for
good works!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be generic,
glamorous, gluttonous, groggy, gloomy, guilty, grim,

always having a gimmick and the Christian life becomes nothing more than a game!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be generous, genuine, gentle, glad, going, growing, good-hearted, grateful, and grandiose! It will be a church which will get the garbage out, become goal oriented, gather the golden grain of the last day harvest for the glory of God, and will gain the prize at the end of the race!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be half-hearted, hard-hearted, hamstrung, halting, hampered, haphazard, hasty, haughty, and hateful! It will be handicapped, hesitant, hurt, hysterical, constantly involved in half truths, hung up on heresies, and hobbling through life holding to a crutch of worldliness! It will have more hang-ups than hand-bells and will believe that a homosexual tendency can be turned into an alternate lifestyle that will be approved by God!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be hearty, healthy, honorable, holy, heroic and heterosexual! It will homestead on the ground of holiness, becomes the habitation of God, heirs to promise, headed to heaven, and possesses hope which is the anchor of the soul! Bill Clinton is not the only one who believes in a place called Hope!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be intolerant, imbalanced, indifferent, immobile, impotent, incompetent, indulgent, intoxicated, infirmed, insensitive, introverted and ill-mannered! It will be

impatient, idolatrous, idle, ignorant, impersonal,
intoxicated with this world, and so intellectual that
professing themselves to be wise they become fools!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be inspirational,
inclusive, imposing, increasing, indigenous and
informed! It will itch to insulate the world from
judgment and believe in baptism by immersion! Its
work will be immeasurable, it will be identified by the
illumination that it attempts to interject into this world
and it will take its instructions from the great I am!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be juvenile, lack
judgment, continuously under the juniper tree,
constantly jumping to conclusions, and a joke in the
eyes of the world!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be joyful,
jubilant and justified in the sight of God!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be known for its
love of the world, and the kiss of death to its
adherents!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be kind,
knowledgeable and a key to reaching a world on their
way to hell! It will be the kiss of life to those who are
spiritually dead and a kiss of peace to those who have
been tossed to and fro on life's angry sea! It will have
a close kinship with the spirits of just men made
perfect!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be lazy, legalistic, limited, loving leisure, liberal, lustful, in limbo, lapsing into lethargy, the living dead, large in its own eyes but little in God's eyes!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be loving, legitimate, lasting, loyal, labeled as lunatics and laboring for the Lord who loves it! It will be a life support system for those who have already been counted out, lightening the loads of the heavy laden, launching laymen into ministry, believe in the laying on of hands and will be learning the language of heaven!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be mainstream, modern, moderate, manipulative, mercenary, marginal, misled, mixed up, melancholy, melodramatic and always marching on middle ground! It will be mincing words, masquerading as the true Church, and mimicking a morgue!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be marked, merciful, mighty, militant, magnificent, meritorious, magnetic and very matter-of-fact! It will be maligned, misunderstood and misused! It will be motivated, multiplying, have a made up mind and manifesting miracles! It will magnify the Messiah and make the devil mad! It will have a magnanimous message to preach, moving in the manifestation of the gifts of the spirit and marching to the beat of a different drummer!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be napping,
negligent, needy, nervous, neutral, non-cooperative
and always nagging about nothing!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be nice, noble,
noisy, nailed to the cross with Christ, neutralizing the
nature of sin and negating the nights in the lives of its
adherents!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be obtuse,
obsessive, obstinate, opinionated, ostentatious, out-
manned, out-gunned, out-smarted, overcharged with
surfeiting, out of the will of God and fulfilling the
great omission!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be orderly,
organized, outfitted, open-hearted, opportunistic and
on target! It will open options and providing
opportunities for the underprivileged! It will be in the
business of operating an outlet for over-comers and
operating under an oath to fulfill the great
commission!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be paganistic,
proud, poison, passive, permissive, political, popular
and suffering from paralysis! It will be promiscuous,
perverse, provocative, pretending and pathetic! It will
be a pawn in the hands of the devil, prejudiced and
panic stricken on judgment day!

If we make it a house of prayer it will set the pace
while being personal! It will be patient, positive, pure,
potent, powerful, productive and peaceful! It will be

Pentecostal, prophetic and partakers of the divine nature! It will be pregnant with a passion for souls, poised to preach the promises of GOD and the perils of pretentious living! It will provide a panorama of paradise and will propel its patrons through the pearly gates!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be quiet, questionable, quarreling, and constantly in a quandary! It will be continuously quenching the spirit, conveniently caught in the quagmire of sin and always on the verge of quitting!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be quaint, quality, qualified, quantitative and will be quick to quiet all quarrels!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be racial, rabid, rotten, repetitious, redundant, reserved and repulsive! It will resist the things of GOD, always railing against that which is right and rambling about without reason!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be repentant, reconciled, refined, ransomed, right, redeemed, refreshed, rested, relaxed, respectful and responsive! It will be radiant, rejoicing, red-hot, radical and revolutionary! It will be rooted and grounded in the Word, resilient, running the race with patience, raining on the devils parade and reaping the rewards of the redeemer!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be sad, shallow, superficial, slick, sarcastic, skeptical and stingy! It

will be shrewd, full of scoffers, scandalized, sick, sinful, slumbering and always sidestepping responsibility! It will attempt to socialize the gospel and becoming silent on the issues which make an eternal difference!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be sacred, sovereign, sanctified, sensible and savvy! It will be scrutinized, stable, settled and shutting down self-destruction! It will be sympathetic, seeing the importance of Christ, sick of the status quo, and smashing the kingdom of darkness to smithereens!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be tantalizing, too tolerant, toxic, treacherous, temporal, tense, tormented, tightfisted, thirsty and full of talebearers! It will be tainting theological truths, becomes a threat to it's adherents, trading truth for transgression and will eventually be terminated by GOD himself!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be teachable, timely, turned around, tuned in, trusting in the trinity and tarrying for Pentecostal power! It will be touched by the hand of GOD, telling the truth, triumphing in truth, transported by triumph, transacting treaties and terminating the tears of those who are hurting!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be unhappy, uncaring, unfeeling, unconcerned and unconscious! It will be unkind, untaught, unwise, unbiblical and unclean! It will be unaware of the sin that is around it, attempting to be undercover, and unable to correct the problems of its society!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be unshakeable, unparalleled, under siege, undefeated, unbreakable, upright, unique, unified and universal! It will umpire ultimatums, underwrite unction and unveiling the unknown!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be vain, vagrant, vengeful, vicious, vulnerable, and create a vacuum in the lives of its adherents!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be valuable, victorious, virtuous, vital and visionary! It will be high voltage, vacating vices and creating viable vessels!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be wasted, watered down, worldly, wild, whipped and always waffling on the issues! It will learn to live with spiritual wantonness and will eventually wail in outer darkness!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be whole, wise, walking the walk, awakening the weary, reaching wretches and willing to work for wages! It will set some high water marks, weather the storm and waiting on a wedding!

If we make it a den of thieves it will be eccentric and eventually excommunicated from the invisible Church!

If we make it a house of prayer it will be excited, exemplifying a good example, prescribing extra

patience and introducing x-sinners to Christ! It will make the expense of living for GOD affordable!

If we make it a den of thieves it will constantly be yakking about things that it does not understand and yawning because of its comatose condition! Without knowing what it is craving it will yearn for the things of GOD!

If we make it a house of prayer it will yield a yoke that is bearable!

If we make it a den of thieves it will produce a zest for life that is wrongly directed!

If we make it a house of prayer it will zero us in on proper zeal, anticipating spiritual Zion, and end up experiencing zero gravity!

The end result of a house of prayer is heaven! 1 Thessalonians 4:16-19 (NKJV) ***“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸Therefore comfort one another with these words.”*** 1

Corinthians 15:51-58 (NKJV) ***“Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵²in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be***

changed. ⁵³For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴So when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” ⁵⁵“O Death, where is your sting? O Hades, where is your victory?” ⁵⁶The sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law. ⁵⁷But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.

⁵⁸Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that your labor is not in vain in the Lord.” Revelation 4:1-2 (NKJV) “After these things I looked, and behold, a door standing open in heaven. And the first voice which I heard was like a trumpet speaking with me, saying, “Come up here, and I will show you things which must take place after this.”

²Immediately I was in the Spirit; and behold, a throne set in heaven, and One sat on the throne.”

PLACES PREACHED:

1ST A/G, Malvern, AR 1995

Trinity A/G, Arkadelphia, AR 1995 Fellowship Meeting

CT Church Houston, TX April, 2007

1st A/G Silsbee, TX, Dedication of new building, April, 2007